part of the interview style format," he says. For Ranveer the rise of influencers like him can be attributed to greater access to technology and cheap internet. "I don't think there's anything special we are doing other than speaking through a youth lens," he adds. On his wishlist of interview subjects: Shashi Tharoor, Nirmala Sitharaman, Annamalai, Arvind Kejriwal, Amit Shah and Asaduddin Owaisi. His most viewed political video — 9.1 million for India's Relations With International Countries, Foreign Policies Explained By Dr. S. Jaishankar.



MR POPULAR

In the battle of followers, PM Modi is miles ahead of Rahul Gandhi, though the gap is smaller between the parties





NARENDRA MODI	BJP		CONGRESS	RAHUL GANDHI
23.7 million	5.98 million	YouTube	5.07 million	6.47 million
89.4 million	8 million	Instagram	5.5 million	8.6 million
	16 million	Facebook	6.8 million	

Data as of May 29

hua Moitra (Humans of Bombay) to BJP leader K. Annamalai (Tamil YouTuber Madan Gowri) has taken the opportunity to engage with the influencers to spread their message to an audience that skips traditional channels of news.

That they are able to do it in an informal setting and without much scrutiny makes them all the more appealing. In a paper titled 'Influencer collaboration on YouTube: Changing political outreach in the 2024 Indian Elections', University of Michigan professor Joyojeet Pal and his two co-authors, Sarah Khan and Rudransh Mukherjee, write, "Influencers allow politicians to present an alternate image of themselves, without the baggage of formality, or the weight of policy conversation. By giving us a glimpse into the lives of politicians in casual settings, influencers can help humanise politicians, and in the same vein an interview with an influencer is also a point at which a politician can save him or herself the inconvenience of difficult questions that a professional journalist can ask."

The approach has worked wonders for Ranveer Allahbadia aka BeerBiceps. MyGov, a platform under the Ministry of Electronics & Information Technology (MeitY) that seeks to build a partnership between citizens, approached him last year to interview cabinet ministers in the Modi government. Inspired by popular podcaster Joe Rogan for his ability to "affect culture" and "redoing the way in which people learn about current affairs", Allahbadia seized the opportunity to interview the likes of external affairs minister S. Jaishankar, minister of commerce and industry Piyush Goyal and the Union minister of state for electronics and information technology Rajeev Chandrasekhar, among others. "My content is for Gen Z and college students," says Allahbadia, who publishes four videos every week and has 10 channels on YouTube. "I like to simplify a lot of political topics and complex issues." Also an engineer by education like Rathee, Allahbadia's interactions with his subjects are less interview and more conversation. From Jaishankar, he wanted to know the role of the sixth sense in geopolitics while Chandrasekhar was asked to comment on the ban of PUBG. "I am smart enough to know not to cross a line," says Allahbadia. "I don't go in to pull out data. I ask tough questions, but in a polite way and most people are willing to answer them."